

HURT VOICES Hindus in Dhaka protest the violence against the community, Aug. 11

AP

BANGLADESH

Hindus in the Cross-fire

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

Every violent, popular insurrection that ousts an authoritarian government leaves behind innocent victims caught in the cross-fire. In Bangladesh, which saw the ouster of the Sheikh Hasina regime on August 5, the blow—physical attacks, looting, property-grabbing, arson—has fallen disproportionately on its minorities, especially the Hindus. It has sparked protests by them in Bangladesh and raised concern in India. Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke to the head of Bangladesh's interim government, Nobel laureate Mohammad Yunus, on August 16, expressing concern about the matter. Now, there are attempts to have a reckoning of sorts. Members of the Hindu Bouddha Christian Unity Council—the largest umbrella organisation of religious minorities in Bangladesh—are collating details of communal violence. It claims that between August 5 and August 8, over 200 incidents of communal persecution took place across 52 districts of the country. But these are conservative numbers based on preliminary information; incidents of violence against minorities over three weeks are estimated to number nearly 1,500, say sources. Even as Yunus has repeatedly stressed on ensuring security for minorities and advocated religious harmony, the Council claims little has changed on the ground.

"Incidents of physical violence and property-grabbing have come down since the initial days of unrest. But fundamentalists have found newer ways to torment minorities," Rana Dasgupta, general secretary of the Council, tells INDIA TODAY from Chattogram. He alleges that Hindu businessmen are being threatened that their establishments would be destroyed unless they pay large ransoms. Then there is the sheer communal coercion of the basest kind—principals, professors and teachers from minority groups across the country are being forced to resign. "Once we have collected details of physical abuse, arson, land-grabbing, rape, murder and other brutalities, we will publish the data. We plan to take it up with the UN. We also plan to collect details of these forced resignations," says Dipangkar Ghosh of the Council's central executive committee.

At least one Hindu organisation in Bangladesh has countered the Council's claims. Gobinda Pramanik, general secretary of the Bangladesh Jatiyo Hindu Mahajot, says many incidents of alleged persecution against minorities are rumours. He claims that during Hasina's Awami League regime, atrocities against Hindus had spiked and yet "everything was hushed" as the former PM "had a secular image to maintain". "She used Hindus as vote banks, spreading a narrative that, in her absence, other political entities will throw us out of Bangladesh. But her dictatorial attitude never spared Hindus," Pramanik says. He is an outlier in claiming that no Hindu has been killed or physically abused for only being a Hindu since August 5. Most violent attacks were political, he says. "(Hindu) Leaders who were part of or close to the Awami League were attacked. This was not because of their religious identity," he adds.

Meanwhile, as reports of atrocities and hundreds of images and videos that purportedly support those claims appear on social media, truth itself has become a casualty. Indeed, fact-checkers from the BBC and DW have busted several such claims on social media as fake. For instance, DW found that images of the house of former Bangladeshi cricketer Mashrafe Mortaza—an

MINORITY REPORT

- **Atrocities against minorities, especially Hindus, have spiked in Bangladesh since the ouster of the Sheikh Hasina regime on Aug. 5**
- **But several videos/ photos/ reports of such 'atrocities' have been found to be fake**
- **The interim government has vowed to protect the rights of minorities**